

What else to watch: *Dead of Night* (1945) ■ *Peeping Tom* (1960, p.334) ■ *The Birds* (1963) ■ *Rosemary's Baby* (1968, p.336) ■ *Death in Venice* (1971) ■ *Walkabout* (1971, p.337) ■ *The Wicker Man* (1973) ■ *The Shining* (1980, p.339)

The movie opens with a slow-motion sequence in which John drags Christine's lifeless body from a pond. It introduces many of the movie's key motifs, including water and the color red.

seems to be a warning. "Don't look now!" it screams, begging the audience to avert its gaze. But, as with many things in Nicolas Roeg's paranormal chiller, the title is not what it seems. In fact Roeg wants the viewer to look carefully, especially at the patterns created by his strange, kaleidoscopic arrangement of images.

The director experimented with complex visual editing in his previous movies, *Performance* (1970) and *Walkabout* (1971); in *Don't Look Now*, he uses these techniques to convey both a sense of menace and the fractured psychological states of his two main characters. Images are repeated and echoed at jarring moments: ripples on water; the color red; breaking glass; close-ups of gargoyles and statues. The viewer glimpses them here and there, just as John catches sight of the scarlet-coated figure from the corner of his eye, and they accumulate to build an atmosphere thick with paranoia.

Love scene

Perhaps the most celebrated example of this fragmented editing style is the sequence in which John and Laura make love for the first time since Christine died. Roeg makes



quick, disjointed cuts between the couple in bed and the two of them dressing for dinner later in the evening. The result is a sex scene unlike any other—intense, touching, melancholic, and comic; and so realistic that many

contemporary viewers assumed the sex was real. This is a movie that forces us to look again, to ask ourselves, "Did I really see that?" John cannot see what is in front of him: that he possesses the gift of second sight. He doesn't believe in psychics, and when Laura tells him that the clairvoyant has "seen" their daughter in Venice, he reacts by getting drunk and angry. Even after he sees Christine's reflection in a canal, rippling across the »

“This one **who's blind.**
She's the one who **can see.**”

Laura Baxter / Don't Look Now